border zone signage, is that the sign will be placed back into the ground upon completion. If not, its full disposal, one could imagine, will only nominally address the geopolitical situation. Together these two pairings epitomize a key observation of Tajiri's imaginative and multifarious wall "sculpture": in the former, the American sector sign is situated in a central city wasteland, a border of alternating hyperactivity and disregard, a sense that both the East and West are working against nature to uphold a border without a true logic; in the latter, a toppled American sector sign conjures a mundane tinkering at this stilted but nonetheless fortified front line. Neither image clarifies the position of the American presence in Berlin or affirms the success or failure of the Berlin Wall, but, rather, they hint at the unresolved status of the city, its border, and its divided people. Tajiri spotlights the arbitrary and purgatorial nature of the Berlin Wall as an illogic of war, the by-product of a longtime military occupation, and an inverse vision of American power abroad. His place, as his own stated method suggests, is as an artist digging to question and comprehend his exiled surroundings.



FIGURE 3.5 Shinkichi Tajiri, *The Berlin Wall, 1969–1970*. (Shinkichi Tajiri Estate)